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Guest Speaker Series Reflection Assignment

As a college student, hearing from seasoned professionals is an excellent way to learn insights about your industry. From this series we heard from leaders such as Steve Arters, Dana Sims, Michelle Beadle, Julian Duncan, and Herm Quiroz Jr, who shared valuable career advice from their personal reflections. In this paper I will discuss which speaker impacted me most, the most valuable lesson I gained, how the speakers connected classroom concepts, how the speakers shifted my perspective, and how I will apply these lessons to my career journey going forward.

While I was impacted by all of the speakers, Dana Sims and Michelle Beadle's stories were most inspiring to me. Ironically enough, what impacted me most wasn't their success (although distinguished), but the trials and tribulations they encountered along their journeys. For instance, Dana Sims worked 20 hours days in the beginning of her career (Sims). And Michelle Beadle, who dropped out of college and worked as waitress for 3 years until she decided to go back to school (Beadle). It has taken me 6 years to finish my college degree. I've often felt behind compared to my peers, but every time I listen to older generations speak on their experiences, I see a common theme: There is no cookie cutter journey to reach success.

The most valuable lesson I learned from this guest speaker series is to "learn everything, do everything and don't worry about being stuck somewhere" (Quiroz Jr). Herm Quiroz Jr said this, but this was a common theme across all the speakers. From the first speaker Steve Arters to the last speaker Herm Quiroz Jr, they all emphasized the importance of trying new things and

facing challenges, because these challenges are often opportunities in disguise. Along with this sentiment, Julian Duncan also emphasized the importance of “playing for the name on the back of the jersey” (Duncan). After 10 years working at Nike, Duncan took a sabbatical that made him realize he was playing too much for the name on the front of the jersey (the company Nike), over himself. He decided to take on a new challenge, working for Under Armour (Duncan).

While I learned career navigational challenges from these leaders, I also learned insights that connect to our class's concepts. In class, we learned about positioning strategies companies use to distinguish their products or services from their competitors. Steve Arters talked about the positioning of the vegetation management machine that Renu Robotics sold solar plants as an innovative product that would eliminate the need for landscaping crews that were often undependable, costly and often lead to damages on site. Another connection I noticed was the creative collaborations Julian Duncan worked on to encourage people to come to basketball games. Collaborations with Hello Kitty and WWE brought in more people, demonstrating that spectators of sporting events are potential consumers of other products.

In some ways, all of the speakers changed my perspective on my career goals and professional development. On the other hand, I also felt that my goals were affirmed and solidified. Hearing the journeys of these speakers was, on a personal level, confrontational. I want to have a job with predictable hours and not work overtime. The speaker stories made me realize that this may not be an option, at least not in my early career. However, I want children someday, so hearing these stories reminded me of the importance of work life balance and remembering what your priorities are.

The speakers of this series shared with us a lot of lessons that I plan to keep in mind as I enter into my career. Some lessons that stood out to me are: “do all the jobs you can” (Beadle),

“I heard no a thousand times” (Beadle), embrace the networking stuff (Beadle), keep company culture in mind (Duncan), understand the consumer you're trying to serve (Duncan), don't take things personally (Duncan) , identify what skills help you stand out as a young professional (Duncan) , learn everything and stay humble (Quiroz Jr). I find each lesson to be equally influential, and I plan to keep these lessons in mind through the application process, hiring process, and in my future career.

The guest speaker series was an insightful experience that I will remember for years to come. It was an honor and privilege to hear from these successful professionals. The speakers impacted me, gave me valuable lessons, connected classroom concepts, shifted my perspective, and I intend to apply these lessons to my career journey going forward.

Works Cited

Arters, Steve. "Guest Speaker Series." MKT 4143 Sports Marketing, 8 April 2026, The University of Texas at San Antonio, Lecture.

Beadle, Michelle. "Guest Speaker Series." MKT 4143 Sports Marketing, 22 April 2026, The University of Texas at San Antonio, Lecture.

Duncan, Julian. "Guest Speaker Series." MKT 4143 Sports Marketing, 29 April 2026, The University of Texas at San Antonio, Lecture.

Quiroz Jr., Herm. "Guest Speaker Series." MKT 4143 Sports Marketing, 6 May 2026, The University of Texas at San Antonio, Lecture.

Sims, Dana. "Guest Speaker Series." MKT 4143 Sports Marketing, 15 April 2026, The University of Texas at San Antonio, Lecture.